

can have. We've blocked close to about 1.75 crore phones that are either not a certain person's number through this portal," he stated.

What's interesting is that the platform seems capable of solving one of the biggest problems in India, recovering stolen phones. "We have recovered close to five lakh stolen phones and taken them back to the original owner through this portal," he added.

ASTR: AI at work

To counter more sophisticated scams, the government is deploying AI-driven tools. One such tool is the ASTR app, developed by the DoT, which uses data intelligence to detect and disconnect fraudulent mobile connections.

"We've got a new app that the DoT has come up with called ASTR... we've disconnected 82 lakh numbers based on that," he said.

Scindia explained that these numbers were flagged for using fraudulent technology to obtain multiple SIM cards or bypass telecom checks.

CIOR: Blocking spoofed international calls

International spoof calls, where scam calls appear as Indian numbers despite originating abroad, have been a long-term problem. Scindia, during the interview, stated that the government has introduced a system called CIOR

ASTR: A key weapon in DoT's arsenal

Here are 5 key statistics and figures related to ASTR (AI-based System for Telecom Analytics) by DoT India as of 2025:

1. ASTR has helped disconnect around 78 million (7.8 crore) unauthorized mobile connections identified as fraudulent or made with fake documents through AI-based analysis.
2. It operates as a crucial component of the government's telecom fraud detection strategy, working alongside inputs from other stakeholders and citizen feedback to collectively disconnect over 3.4 crore (34 million) connections nationwide.
3. ASTR's analysis also supports blocking or restricting suspicious mobile devices and connections in real-time to prevent telecom-related cybercrimes.
4. The system aids in identifying and exposing fraud schemes involving multiple connections obtained under one individual's name, addressing the issue of exceeding mobile connection limits at the subscriber level.
5. By applying big data analytics and AI, ASTR enhances the effectiveness and speed of enforcement actions, significantly reducing telecom fraud incidents and contributing to improved user security in the Indian telecom ecosystem.

(Calling Identification Out-Roaming Registry) to combat this menace.

"Earlier, people would receive calls that appeared to be from Indian numbers but were actually international spoofed calls. Through the CIOR software, we were able to block around 1.35 crore such calls per day. Today, all those spoofing gateways have been blocked, and the number of spoof calls coming into India has reduced by 97%, down to

just 3.3 lakh calls a day," he said, which is a remarkable positive turnaround.

Financial risk indicator: Tagging high-risk users

Beyond telecom systems, the DoT is collaborating with financial institutions to monitor and freeze high-risk accounts through a tool called the Financial Fraud Risk Indicator (FRI).

"We've also introduced a system called the Financial Fraud Risk Indicator (FRI), where all financial institutions are onboarded. Individuals are tagged as high, very high, or medium risk based on their likelihood to commit financial fraud. So far, close to three lakh bank accounts have been frozen under this system, along with nearly 1.5 lakh debit and credit cards," he added.

Scindia concluded the conversation with a firm message that the government remains vigilant.

"We are on the prowl, quote unquote, and it is our job to ensure that we stop every fraudulent transaction from taking place. Some will inevitably slip through the cracks, but we are on it. Let me assure you," he said. **d**

